

APPENDIX E

“A RECOLLECTION” [HỒI ỨC]

BY TRỊNH CÔNG SƠN

In this essay Trịnh Công Sơn talks about Ngô Thị Bích Diễm, the girl who inspired him to compose what is probably his most famous love song, “Diễm xưa” [Diễm of the Past]. The location of the scene described is in the southern part of the city of Huế. Diễm lived on the southern side of the Bến Ngự [Royal Wharf] River, so named because this was where the king docked the royal barge. Trịnh Công Sơn lived on the north side in an apartment complex on Nguyễn Trường Tộ Street. The bridge Diễm crossed was called the Phú Cam Bridge because it led to the Phú Cam Church.*

Once there was a very slender girl who walked through rows of camphor trees with tiny green leaves on her way to the Faculty of Letters at the University of Huế.

For many days, many months, during that period, this girl would walk under the dome of these camphor trees.

For numerous sunny seasons and wet seasons she would pass by. During the sunny seasons the cicadas would noisily sing a summer song in the leaves. When she passed by during the Huế's spring rainy season,

she would appear dimly in the rain between the two dark rows of camphor trees.

Her house was across the river and each day to get to school she had to cross a bridge and walk along the street lined with camphor trees.

From the balcony of my home I watched her pass by, going and returning, four times each day. At that time girls in Huế did not ride noisy vehicles that moved at dizzying speeds as they do now. Except for people who lived far away and had to go by bicycle, most slowly walked to school, moving in a leisurely and regal manner. They walked to be admired, to feel quietly in their hearts that they were beautiful. Whether they showed off their beauty to be admired by many people or only one person is not important. Those footsteps from many directions lead to many schools with familiar and sometimes very old names. They walked so others could observe them but also so, at the same time, they had time to observe the earth, the rivers, the flowers and trees of nature. Camphor, almond, red royal Poinciana, sumac, laurel, and also the Perfume River that flows around the city—all these things had been blowing a pure romantic mist into their souls since they were young. That's why Huế never ceases to be a source of inspiration. An ancient citadel, temples and palaces, imperial tombs—all these things make people long for the past and help free them from the troubles of the world. As a result Huế becomes a private space, a private world. It's not as enticing as a large metropolis but it is the source of gentle personal emotions which suddenly turn people into dreamers who wish for worlds that are not completely real.

But what are reality and dreams? Truthfully, when all is said and done, the former is an illusion of the latter. And after having those illusions for a rather long time, people who grow up in that small city weave and embroider their own dreams.

That also was a time when on each pure morning, each afternoon, each evening, the bell at Linh Mụ Pagoda echoed in the air above the river, arriving at each partially shuttered or closed in house.

Time passed very quietly here—so quietly that people did not have a perception of time. It was a time with no shape, no color. Only when old people died in the coldness of winter did one wake up and suddenly become aware of the whisperings of tombs and graves in the surrounding hills and mountains.

In that quiet and dreamy time, and in that vaguely surreal [*liêu trai*] atmosphere, that girl continued to pass by each day between the two

rows of camphor trees on her way to school. She was going to school but sometimes it seemed as if she were headed toward an indefinite place, a direction that was not a direction, because those steps seemed to float on a happy cloud of dreams.

In harsh hot and rainy seasons that girl crossed a bridge and walked under camphor trees to arrive finally at her rendezvous location. But a rendezvous doesn't mean something is promised. Because in that surreal time a promise was an unbelievable fantasy. No surreal dream will ever come true: All are bound to disappear.

That girl who walked through those rows of camphor trees now lives in a faraway place and has a different life. Everything that remains is only a memory. All memories are worth remembering but at some point must be forgotten. That girl was Diễm of bygone days.

APPENDIX F

“PLAYING GAMES” [TRÒ CHƠI]

BY TRỊNH CÔNG SƠN

I do not know where this article first appeared. To my knowledge it has not been reprinted in any journal or book, but it can be found online at the following website: <https://trinhcongsonblog.wordpress.com/2013/08/17/tro-choi/>.

The following translation is by Cao Thị Như Quỳnh.

When you feel that the game of life has something disturbing about it, then look for a quiet place, close the doors and pretend that you have thrown yourself into a fit of dreamlike pain. Choose whatever pain you like but make sure it's painful—so excruciatingly painful that death has the opportunity to gaze at you and test your fate. And when you reach a point that seems the most hopeless, suddenly from distant meadows healthy breezes arrive, bringing with them a fragrance of green rice, mint, and wild flowers. These breezes revive you and bring to life again the spring seasons that lie asleep, forgotten in your veins. That is also a time of rebirth of small living things in the swamps and of the awakening of wise men on high mountains or in deep grottos.

In a month when you must visit five or seven seriously ill patients, attend ten funerals and twenty weddings (including in one case two or three in an hour), then that fiendish month is no longer fun. It is a hellish game. When a game becomes hellish there is no reason to play it anymore. It's better to withdraw and run away quickly.

Perhaps of all the games the game of friends causes the least grief. It can be either a lot of fun or only a little fun, but it doesn't cause heartrending